and set a new course. After sailing for yet another twelve days, the ship finally arrived on the Chinese coast. Thus ends one of the earliest accounts of a sea journey between India and China. It reminds us that Indian Ocean voyages were dangerous and that these ancient merchants ran enormous risks when they set sail for foreign lands.

REBUILDING THE IMPERIAL DREAM

When Fa Xian visited India, much of the country was under the sway of the Gupta Empire, the second of India's great empires. The first of the Gupta emperors was Chandragupta I (320–335 AD) who established control over the eastern Gangetic plain with his capital in Pataliputra (now Patna). However, it was his son Samudragupta who dramatically expanded the empire over his forty-year rule. He first ensured that he had control of the entire Gangetic plains. Then he led a campaign deep into southern India where he reduced the kings of the region, including the Pallavas, to tributary status. Having proved himself as the most powerful monarch in the subcontinent, he performed the Vedic ritual of the Ashwamedha Yagna and proclaimed himself the Chakravartin or Universal Monarch.

Samudragupta's successor Chandragupta II (also called Vikramaditya) next expanded the empire westward to include Malwa and Gujarat by defeating the Sakas (or Scythians) who had ruled this area for several generations. Many of the small kingdoms and republics of north-west India were also reduced to tributary status. Thus, the Guptas established effective sway over much of India. In North and Central India, this control was exercised directly, while in peninsular India and in the north-west it was exercised indirectly through tributaries and close allies like the Vakatakas.

There is strong evidence to suggest that the Guptas consciously modelled themselves on the Mauryans and set out to recreate the empire of their predecessors. Not only did two of their emperors share a name with Chandragupta Maurya, but the Guptas went out of their way to put their own inscriptions next to Mauryan ones. For instance, much of what we know about the conquests of Samudragupta is from inscriptions carved on